

Chapter 3

Shadows of Yesterday

Elara officially joined **Northbridge Group**, one of Germany's leading real estate and construction companies.

Its headquarters stood in the heart of Frankfurt.

The towering glass building reflected the morning sunlight, while hundreds of employees hurried through the revolving doors, each carrying the weight of another busy day.

The company had been founded by Elara's father years ago.

Over time, it had grown into one of the country's most respected business groups with the support of his closest friend and business partner...

Ethan's father.

As the elevator reached the twenty-fifth floor, the doors slid open.

"Good morning, Miss Elara."

Employees greeted her with polite smiles.

She returned every greeting with quiet confidence.

A young woman approached her with a tablet in her hands.

"Good morning, Miss Elara."

"My name is Emma."

"I'll be your personal assistant."

"It's nice to meet you."

Elara smiled warmly.

"It's nice to meet you too, Emma."

Emma guided her through a bright hallway before stopping in front of a large wooden door.

She gently pushed it open.

"This is your office."

Elara stepped inside.

For a brief moment...

She forgot everything outside those walls.

The office was elegant without being overwhelming.

A wall of glass overlooked Frankfurt's skyline.

Sunlight poured across the polished wooden floor.

A bookshelf filled with architecture, business and design books stood beside the window.

A small coffee corner occupied one side of the room.

Fresh white lilies rested in a crystal vase on the desk, filling the room with a soft fragrance.
A framed quote hung neatly on the wall.
"Success means nothing if it costs you your peace."
Elara slowly walked toward the window.
The city stretched endlessly beneath her.
Cars moved like tiny lights below.
For the first time in a long while...
She took a deep breath.
"It feels peaceful," she whispered.
"I'm glad you like it."
The familiar voice made her turn.
Ethan stood at the doorway with a relaxed smile.
"So..."
"Miss Director."
"How does it feel?"
Elara couldn't help smiling.
"A little overwhelming."
"I expected you to say boring."
"I've only been here for two minutes."
"Give it another ten."
Both of them laughed softly.
Emma smiled before excusing herself.
"I'll bring today's schedule."
As the door closed...
The room became quiet again.
"I'm really glad you joined us," Ethan said.
"You've spent enough time hiding from the world."
Elara looked at the skyline outside.
"Maybe."
"Or maybe I just needed something to keep my mind busy."
Ethan didn't ask another question.
He simply nodded.
Sometimes...
Silence was kinder than curiosity.

The rest of the day passed in meetings, introductions and endless paperwork.

By evening...

Elara felt mentally exhausted.

As she placed the last file on her desk, her phone vibrated.

A message appeared in their group chat.

Daniel:

"Since someone finally survived her first day at work..."

"Dinner tonight?"

A second later...

Another notification appeared.

Ava:

"I'm finally back from France, and none of you are allowed to make excuses."

Daniel replied almost instantly.

"Exactly! We finally have everyone in one city again."

A small smile appeared on Elara's face.

She hadn't seen Ava in months.

France had always been her dream.

She had spent the past several months there, working with a well-known fashion house and learning from some of the industry's best designers.

Now...

She was finally home.

Ethan glanced at Elara's phone and smiled.

"So..."

"Are we going?"

Elara looked at the messages for a few quiet seconds.

Then she typed...

"I'll be there."

She slipped her phone into her bag and looked out across the city one last time.

Outside...

Frankfurt was glowing beneath the evening sky.

Inside...

She had no idea that this dinner would quietly bring old memories back to the surface...

The restaurant overlooked the River Main.

Soft piano music filled the air as warm lights reflected against the glass windows.

Daniel was already there.

The moment he saw Elara, he stood dramatically and placed a hand over his heart.

"Finally..."

"Our businesswoman has arrived."

Elara rolled her eyes.

"You've been waiting for five minutes."

"I've been emotionally waiting for weeks."

She laughed.

"I missed that terrible sense of humor."

Daniel grinned.

"See? I'm still talented."

Before either of them could say another word...

A familiar voice interrupted.

"I leave Germany for a few months..."

"And you two still haven't grown up."

Both of them turned.

Ava stood a few steps away.

Her long beige coat rested elegantly over a black dress, while a soft smile lit up her face.

Without saying a word...

Elara walked straight toward her.

The two hugged tightly.

"I missed you," Elara whispered.

"I missed you more."

Daniel folded his arms dramatically.

"Excuse me..."

"Am I invisible?"

Ava laughed.

"Unfortunately..."

"No."

The three of them laughed together.

For the first time in what felt like forever...

Everything almost felt normal.

A few moments later...

Ethan arrived.

"Sorry I'm late."

"Board meeting."

Daniel sighed dramatically.

"You're becoming old."

"I'm becoming responsible."

"No..."

Daniel replied.

"You're becoming boring."

Even Ethan laughed.

The evening passed with light conversations.

Ava shared stories about France...

The tiny cafés.

Late-night fashion workshops.

The excitement of seeing her designs displayed for the first time.

Daniel couldn't stop teasing her.

"So..."

"When are we meeting the mysterious fiancé?"

Ava smiled shyly.

"Soon."

"You'll all meet him."

"Hopefully."

Daniel raised an eyebrow.

"Hopefully?"

She laughed.

"You'll understand when you meet him."

Dinner arrived.

The table slowly filled with laughter...

With stories...

With memories.

Until...

Daniel suddenly looked at the empty chair beside the table.

His smile faded.

"It still feels strange..."

"Noah would've ordered dessert before dinner."

Silence.

No one laughed.

No one replied.

Elara lowered her eyes.

Ava quietly looked away.

Even Ethan's smile disappeared for a brief moment.

Some absences...

Never stopped being felt.

Daniel forced a smile.

"She would've complained about my jokes too."

Ava nodded softly.

"And then laughed at them anyway."

A faint smile returned to everyone's face.

Not because the pain was gone...

But because remembering Noah together somehow made losing her a little less lonely.

A while later...

Elara excused herself.

"I'll be back in a minute."

She walked toward the restroom at the end of the hallway.

Cold water ran over her hands.

She looked at her reflection in the mirror.

For a moment...

Everything was quiet.

She took a slow breath before turning to leave.

The moment she stepped into the hallway...

She froze.

A fragrance drifted through the air.

Warm.

Woody.

With the fresh scent of bergamot resting beneath soft sandalwood.

Her heartbeat skipped.

Why...

Why did this scent feel so familiar?

She closed her eyes for only a second.

An unfamiliar ache settled deep inside her chest.

As if her heart remembered something...
Her mind had forgotten.
Elara slowly opened her eyes and looked around.
The hallway was almost empty.
Only the sound of an elevator echoed in the distance.
The doors slid shut.
Whoever had been there...
Was already gone.
She remained standing for a few silent seconds...
Still surrounded by that fading fragrance.
Without realizing it...
Her fingers gently brushed the tiny beauty mark on her right hand.
Then...
She quietly walked back toward the table.
Leaving behind nothing...
Except a question she couldn't answer.